

Playing with LIVES

With the death toll from the Maoist insurgency on the rise, the corruption in the procurement of bulletproof jackets is an alarming pointer to official connivance

By Sandeep Unnithan

For years, R.K. and Laveena Gupta stood for the rapidly expanding private footprint in the state-monopolised defence business. The rags-to-riches story of the entrepreneur couple was unusual only in the sector they chose: the body armouring business. Now, after their arrest by the CBI on charges of corruption, the engineer couple could well be the new face of an old malaise: corruption. The Guptas who run Rs 120-crore Noida-based Anjani Technoplast Pvt Ltd, India's largest body armouring firm, have been charged with paying Rs 10-lakh bribe to Radhe Shyam Sharma, an official with the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA). The case has to do with an order for 20,000 bulletproof jackets placed in March last year to urgently provide protection to police and paramilitary personnel. This fast-track acquisition came in the wake of the 26/11 Mumbai attacks when suicide gunmen of the Lashkar-e-Toiba exposed critical vulnerabilities of policemen in armour and weaponry.

The firm completed deliveries of the jackets worth around Rs 36 crore

by May 21, 2009. But where did Sharma, the mid-level MHA official fit in? Indian Railway and Engineering Service official Sharma, is believed to have played a key role in this acquisition. As Director (Provisioning), Sharma is responsible for formulating qualitative requirements for equipment. He had to sign off on proposals to modernise not just the paramilitary forces but also the state police forces whose modernisation is funded by the MHA. He would know about practically every tender in the MHA. The CBI has charged Sharma with leaking confidential data about the tenders and trial process. A police official says that prices are routinely inflated in procurement related cases. "It is so blatant that manufacturers often approach senior officials and ask them 'what is the price you want us to quote?'" The inflated amount is skimmed away by the manufacturer and shared with the official.

Yet, these were not tenders for ordinary stores which were being passed but critical life-saving equipment. The CBI is investigating whether Anjani had greased palms of a wider net within the MHA to get substandard bulletproof jackets passed, endangering the lives they were meant to pro-

tect. Former IPS officer Y.P. Singh calls this scam 'a collapse of ethicality and a possible replay of the circumstances that lead to the death of ATS chief Hemant Karkare'. "He got killed because he was wearing a substandard jacket. But even this has failed to deter corrupt officials," says Singh, who



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